

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*How to Create a Life:
Finding Our Way in Chaotic Times*
PRIDE SUNDAY

June 15th, 2025



The Miracle of Light While Flying ~ Gerardo Dottori 1931

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in- Residence*

Improvisation on SLANE and ABBOT'S LEIGH

Over The Rainbow - Organ Solo (Harold Arlen, E.Y. Harburg; arr. C. Bull)

Nothing Compares 2 Prince - Mash-up of Nothing Compares 2 U & Purple Rain
(Prince, arr. C. Bull)

Autobahn-Toccata - *When Bach met Kraftwerk*
(Johann Sebastian Bach, Ralf Hütter, Florian Schneider, Emil Schult; arr. C. Bull)

Born This Way (Germanotta/Laursen/Garibay/Blair, arr. C. Bull)

Over The Rainbow - Piano & Vocals (Harold Arlen, E.Y. Harburg)
Molly Pease, *Vocalist*, Christoph Bull, *Pianist*

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Rev. Fregin, Yulia Fox & Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

Today, in this place, and in this time,
we claim ourselves as children who belong
to the Divine, and to each other,
as we celebrate the beauty and individual worth of all creation.

We believe in a God:
*who created each of us, who breathed into us our uniqueness,
who delights in who we are, and what we can still become.*

We believe in the love of God:
*who laughs with us in our joy, who cries with us in our pain,
who wants all creation to seek peace, reconciliation,
and love for each other.*

We believe in the justice of God:
*as revealed in sacred stories and texts
and through the lives of people
whose words and actions show them to be
holy prophets.*

*God alone created us. We are not alone;
God loves us. Nothing will separate us
from the love of God.*

May it be so...
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

All the Colors of the Rainbow

ABBOT'S LEIGH

All the colors of the rainbow live unseen in daily light,
But their splendors find expression when released to human sight;
So the church reveals most beauty where diversity is real:
Breadth of race and class and gender, room for doubt and space to heal.

All the body's parts are wanted, nor can one despise the rest:
Head and hand must work together, as must eye and ear and chest;
So the church needs all its members for a range of ministries:
Varied gifts with one great mission, "Do this for the least of these."

Every language gains more music when the words for peace appear:
Pax, Salaam, Eirini, Heiwa, Pace, Santi, Frieden, Mir.
Though our tongues make sounds that vary all bespeak a common home:
Longing for the end of conflict and a new life in God's Shalom.

Teach us, God, our need of others; through them help us fully live.
Wean us from our selfish habits; let us listen, learn, forgive.
May we see your longed-for image in each human heart and face,
And behold how those around us can be channels of your grace.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

O Holy One, by your grace,
which is and was and ever shall be...
we enter now the sacred realm,
the place of deep connection with you,
with each other, and with all of creation.

By your grace the walls that isolate fall;
fear dissolves into trust;
arrogance is gentled by compassion;
our need to prove ourselves is tempered
by self-acceptance and humility.

Help us now, Holy One, to rest in a love
that helps us see our lives
as part of your great unity
and coherence of grace.

We now join with all creation in proclaiming
the wonder of the universe,
and the glory of being alive
in this our time and place.

We pray this in the name of the One who shows us the way,
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

BENNY ANDERSSON, BJÖRN ALVAEUS,
& STIG ANDERSON, arr. DAVID MADDUX

"Dancing Queen"
Gay Men's Chorus of Los Angeles and Cathedral Choir, Brandon Harris, *Director*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

*Holy Being,
whom we call by many different names,
Blessed are you,
Blessed are we in you.*

*May we create with you
a realm of mercy, peace, and justice.
May love be done in the here and now
as it is in the infinite.
May we share life in bread and hope.*

*For our failure to love, we need forgiveness.
May we find the paths of reconciliation.
In the midst of evil's incarnation,
from the powers that have power over our spirits
and our structures, may we find liberation.*

*In the power that is love,
we seek to live and move and have our being.
May it be so,
now and forever.
Amen and Amen.* [nancylsteeves]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

In the beauty of this day and in the light of the rainbow
that shines over this gathered community,
let us remember that our God is always and forever
with us, and for us!

May the Peace and Love of God be with you all.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Children's Pentecost Conversation

Claire Kelly

Following this conversation, children are invited to join us for our Sunday morning programming which is held outside near the playground. If you were unable to check your children in prior to the service, please accompany them to our Children's Area in the narthex and check them in before returning to the service. Children must be picked up after worship before you head to Coffee Hour in the Courtyard.

Readings from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

Yulia Fox & Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

from 1st Corinthians 13

For these words of the ancients whose wisdom we welcome in our present,
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

A strong rainbow pours itself out,
bending the eastern sky with glory,
it brings with it a powerful beauty
to soothe my needy heart with hope.

And I do believe I hear the sun
wild with wonder and rejoicing,
laughing at the once-darkened sky
now parted in colored splendor.

I remember then the One who came,
who broke our stormy night apart,
and shook despairing hearts with hope;
this One told truth of things beyond
and gave us more than gold.

This rainbow filling late-June sky
touches more than just the earth;
it makes its mark within my depth
and lets my heart look up in hope.

-Joyce Rupp

Silence

Prayers of Our Hearts

Holy and Loving God,
with a heart of compassion and arms flung wide,
you call us to be a people of extravagant welcome.
Creating us in your image, you bless us with bodies
that are holy.

Each and every day, you call us to live with integrity,
as we claim the wholeness and holiness
found within your Gospel of Life.

Ever Faithful God, you strengthen us with the power
of your love that casts out fear.
You clarify our vision that we may see ourselves,
and others, as you see us.

And then, Powerful and Tender God,
you empower us to live the amazing and inclusive invitation
of your Gospel, with the incredible gift of courage.

Help us, O God, in the days to come,
to feel your presence that is always with us, and for us.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"We Stand With The Little Children"

C. HERBERT WOOLSTON, arr. ERNEST H. HARRISON

Gay Men's Chorus of Los Angeles and Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ernest H. Harrison, *Director*

Sermon

"Out For Love"

Rev. Tanaka Pack

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

With our eyes wide open, we come to this table
knowing the realities of our world.
We live in a time and place
where words are honed to have painful edges,
where fear too often reigns,
and shards of broken trust are used as weapons,
rending into tatters relationships once built on love.

And yet, in this too-fragile world,
we look - and we find - ways to strengthen love
in all our relationships,
to live in ways that lift each other's souls,
and build, for every single person,
a place that we might all know
the beauty of being celebrated for who we are.

At this table we break bread, share stories, build new and
hope-filled memories as we let go of the hurts and heartaches
of other times and other tables.

At this table we fill ourselves up with the things of love
that we might live strong and confident
in the places we hold in this world.

As those who hold a vision of a love-filled world,
we break this bread as Jesus did,
and we eat together knowing it is the bread of new life.

We also pour and share a cup as Jesus did,
because we want others to come and drink
this cup of hope along with us.

There are no barriers at this table,
because it is a table with a place set for every single one of us.
It is the table of Jesus—a table that has room for all of us.

*Today, we will share Rainbow Hawaiian Bread and gluten free wafers,
with grape juice for Communion.*

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"Freedom Come"

BEN ALLAWAY

Gay Men's Chorus of Los Angeles and Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ernest H. Harrison, *Director*, Lorenzo Zapata, *Soloist*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Yulia Fox

Holy God, we are your people, created in your image.
In our diversity we have strength;
in our shared humanity a common hope,
a vision of life unbound by time.

We have come together to celebrate,
to reflect, and to recommit ourselves to your work.
Shake us out of our complacency,
rock our comfortable certainties
and challenge us to recognize the face of the Christ
in the eyes of everyone we meet.

May our hearts be open to the challenge
of your call to true freedom,
our minds and hands ready
to grasp the opportunity for change.

Inspire us with your message,
open us to the joy of your word,
and guide us as we prepare
to answer your call to open our doors
even wider in this place, we call home.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Words of Blessing

Rev. Tanaka Pack

As we leave this place,
let us remember who we are...

We are the people who heal each other,
who grow strong together,
who know what it means
to live in community,
moving towards a common dream
for a world filled with inclusiveness,
compassion, and generosity
found in the power of the love of God,
the company of the Christ,
and the leading of the Holy Spirit.

Go now in peace,
as those who walk a common way,
and may you find others
to walk on this path with you.
May the hospitality you share
return to you through the love of God
both this day, and forever more.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Hallelujah"

SARAH NUTTING & KARISHA LONGAKER,
arr. DAVID HARRIS

Gay Men's Chorus of Los Angeles and Cathedral Choir, Dr. David Harris, *Director*

***Hymn for the Journey**

God of Many Faces

SLANE

God of many faces, we offer our praise,
singing your glory through all of our days.
Hear ever growing voices, once fragile, now strong,
carrying melodies in expansive new songs.

God of many genders, our world reflects you,
sunrise and sunset uniting our hues,
woven into a city with jewels of all shades,
houses of ruby and walls rowed with jade.

God of many names, we invite you to show
us the new names that reflect our true souls.
Breathe with your holy spirit to give us the Word
that will indwell dry bones, granting new life once heard.

God of many bodies, abide within ours,
shifting more each day through time and through scars.
Come sanctify our bodies, all fashioned by you,
holier every day, still becoming more true.

-lyrics by Amy Cerniglia

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Tutti Frutti (Dorothy La Bostrie and Little Richard)

Inside The Music

"Each year we have the incredible privilege of celebrating PRIDE with GMCLA and the leadership of their world class director Dr. Harrison. EJ and I have become close over the years, and I feel privileged each time he shares his artistry to guide our sacred space. When planning this year, we discussed the increased pressure that the LGBTQI+ community faces in this moment. EJ offered his new "We Stand With The Little Children" as a focal point. When Rev. Woolston first wrote "Jesus Loves The Little Children" at the turn of the 19th century, it carried a profound justice call. Over the 20th century, it became one of the most ubiquitous hymns among all Christians. The soft simplicity of his message, that we are all loved, penetrated even the most hardened minds in its way. Over time, though, the language of his era became dated. EJ has brought the core expression of love from Rev. Woolston's original into our contemporary justice movement. He's broadened the compassion, and given the song legs so that we might take it into the streets with us. We are graced with its premiere this week, and I hope it will receive many more hearings. EJ also suggested Allaway's "Freedom Come." It encourages us to keep our minds clear. When we remain committed to the work of justice, and share with one another the energies necessary to bolster ourselves for the struggle, we have a chance to weather together. As we approach Juneteenth I am reminded of the saying that every generation has to redefine the struggle for freedom for itself. To be in this space with you all, and with GMCLA gives me courage and hope as we create that definition for now." – Dr. Fahad Siadat